



Lake Baikal

The world's largest freshwater lake is Lake Baikal in southern Siberia. This 25-million-year-old lake holds about 20 percent of the planet's fresh surface water.

Nenet people

Deep in the Siberian Arctic, on the Yamal Peninsula, live the Nenets.

These nomadic reindeer herders wear thick furs to survive the subzero temperatures.



Dancers from Moscow's famous Bolshoi Ballet perform Don Quixote.



Russian ballet

Russia is renowned for its classical ballet tradition and is where some of the most famous ballets, such as Swan Lake, were created.

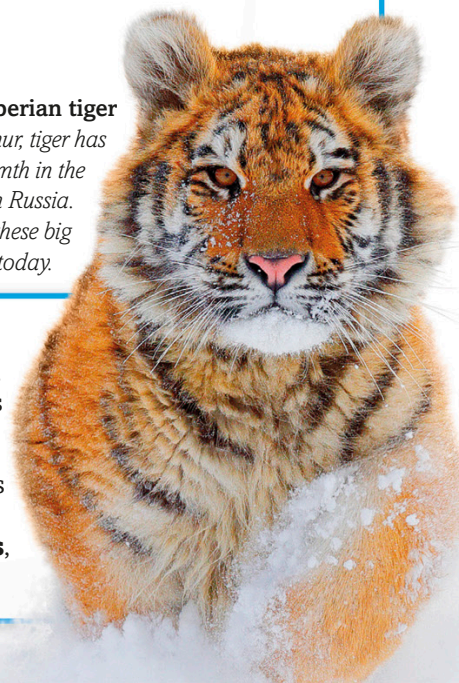
Long journey

Trains running on the main line of the Trans-Siberian Railway network take eight days to complete the journey from Moscow in the west to Vladivostok in the east, a distance of 5,772 miles (9,289 km).



Siberian tiger

The Siberian, or Amur, tiger has thick fur for extra warmth in the icy forests of eastern Russia. Only about 500 of these big cats survive in the wild today.



Geography: The vast terrain covers mountains, forests, treeless tundra, grassy steppes, and deserts. Europe's longest river, the Volga, flows through central Russia.



History: Russia was ruled by monarchs called czars until the 1917 Revolution, when Communists took control and created the Soviet Union. This fell in 1991.



Culture: Russia's rich culture includes the literature of Tolstoy, the music of Tchaikovsky, and athletes such as tennis star Maria Sharapova.



Wildlife: Russia's diverse habitats are home to the Eurasian lynx, Amur leopards, red deer, brown bears, beluga whales, and Oriental storks.